You Can Lead a Mouse to Water

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No Archive Warnings Apply

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She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra)

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Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), a cute little mouse

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Fluff, Tooth-Rotting Fluff, Voicemail, (so many voicemails), Protective Adora (She-Ra), (specifically protective about the mouse), Alternate Universe - Modern Setting, Modern AU but still Canon Species, Adora Is a Mess (She-Ra), POV Catra (She-Ra), Humor, (god this is so funny)

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You Can Lead a Mouse to Water

by Alex_The_Manliest

Summary

Second new message. Received today, at twelve twenty-three a.m.

Adora's voice was cracklier than before. "Okay. I know this is even more dumb, but I—I just wanted to tell you—character growth moment. It's been, like, an hour, and the mouse is still out here, in the same spot. I, um, I think it's dehydrated. It was over ninety degrees today, and the city is still, um. Pretty sticky?" Adora paused for a moment, taking an audible deep breath. "I'm bringing it some water. And I'm… I'm terrified. Of it. I'm terrified of the mouse. I—" Another shaky breath. Her voice suddenly dropped to a horrified whisper. "Oh my God, I'm *scared of a mouse*."

There was a long silence, and then:

Third new message. Received—

Catra ended the call. She couldn't breathe. Trembling with unvoiced laughter, she checked her call log.

Seven. Seven missed calls.

After going on her first ever hiking date, Catra barely made it into bed before she passed out. Daylight brought with it a few unexpected things.

Waking up early, for one; waking up feeling rested, for another; and waking up to… a slew of voicemails? From Adora?

What the fuck did she miss?

Notes

Totally not inspired by real events. *Certainly* not directly quoting any voice messages/voicemails I personally have received. *Unequivocally* not the funniest thing I have ever had the honour and pleasure of being in the front-row seat for.

I am personally referring to this as mousefic and no one can stop me.

See the end of the work for more notes

The last thing Catra remembered doing was texting Adora *i'm alive* through bleary eyes. If the message didn't have any typos, it would be a miracle.

It was the first early night Catra had had in… far too long. She swore, up and down, that hiking was not, is not, *will not* be her thing. But Adora had made it more than tolerable.

Catra might regret not taking her up on being carried back down, though.

Regardless, there was clearly some truth to exhausting the body for a good night's sleep. Even waking up was more pleasant than usual—blinking into consciousness with a quiet hum rather than a disgruntled groan.

Could she… get used to this?

A predictable prickle of discomfort started buzzing at the base of her skull. Her ears had instinctively flattened to her head, hackles already partially raised at the thought alone.

Yeah, that's more like it.

She pawed around the pillow for her phone. It was warm to the touch. She had absolutely no recollection of plugging it in to charge. The screen lighting up didn't even burn her eyes. If there was such a thing as being *too* functional, this might have been it.

Then she saw the time.

Catra was awake. Well-rested. On a weekend. At seven-fucking-thirty in the morning. Catra had found the point of no return; *this* was too functional.

What was she supposed to do? Start her day? The idea felt plain *wrong*.

She should probably check that Adora got back safe. She hadn't exactly waited around for a response before crashing out.

So, still mostly curled up under the covers, Catra lazily thumbed her way through to their text thread.

Right at the top was hers.

Yesterday, [8:52 p.m.]
i'm alibe

Catra swallowed her embarrassment.

Miracles aren't real, after all.

But why was her text at the *top*? She let her gaze drift down to see, separated by time codes, a handful of missed call alerts. All with voicemails attached.

Her grip on the phone tightened considerably. Something heavy sank deep into her lungs.

What the fuck did she miss?

Before she could think any better of it, she pressed the link to listen to her voicemails.

The dumb robot message lady started her usual preamble.

Blood was rushing through her ears as she jerkily sat herself up in bed, panic starting to simmer, low and nearly painful. She knew, without looking, that her tail was probably doubled in size. The sudden movement sent her phone clattering out of her hand and off the edge. She cursed, lunging after it and hastily putting it on speaker.

—new message. Received yesterday, at eleven oh-six p.m.

"Um. Hello." Adora's voice was a little tinny, but there was a noticeable tremor of nerves that pierced through the poor

connection. "You've probably already fallen asleep." A beat, a sharp inhale. "Oh, this is *so* dumb. I, uh. I wanted to call and say what a—what a great time I had, today. And about seeing you again, tomorrow. But—"

Catra closed her eyes. She could feel the rejection lining up its shot. Had Adora really waited until she got home to say it? It was probably better this way. Whatever. *Whatever*.

"But I got, um, distracted? By a… by a mouse."

Catra's eyes snapped back open. That… *wasn't* what she was expecting.

Adora continued (as voicemails are wont to do): "I went for a walk. Just, a late-night walk. Burning off excess energy or, um, you know." Honestly, Catra didn't know. "And there was this mouse. *Is* this mouse. It's still there, in the road. It seems fine and everything, but—Catra, it should be scared of me, but it started *following* me? Like a baby duckling, like it *imprinted on me* or something. It—it freaked me out! So I—I ran away." Adora huffed out a distressed noise. "Catra, I was running away from a *mouse* in the *middle of the night* like a dumbass."

After a moment, the automated voice started rattling off numbers and instructions. Catra simply stared at the screen.

She'd been prepared for—*so certain*—taken completely off-guard by—

A bizarre laugh ricocheted out of her and echoed strangely throughout her bedroom. It was a shade away from a whimper.

There are other voicemails.

Feverishly, Catra pulled up the keypad and pressed whichever number skipped to the next message.

Second new message. Received today, at twelve twenty-three a.m.

Adora's voice was cracklier than before. "Okay. I know this is even more dumb, but I—I just wanted to tell you—character growth moment. It's been, like, an hour, and the mouse is still out here, in the same spot. I, um, I think it's dehydrated. It was over ninety degrees today, and the city is still, um. Pretty sticky?" Adora paused for a moment, taking an audible deep breath. "I'm bringing it some water. And I'm… I'm terrified. Of it. I'm terrified of the mouse. I—" Another shaky breath. Her voice suddenly dropped to a horrified whisper. "Oh my God, I'm *scared of a mouse*."

There was a long silence, and then:

Third new message. Received—

Catra ended the call. She couldn't breathe. Trembling with unvoiced laughter, she checked her call log.

Seven. Seven missed calls.

Catra was going to need her morning dose of caffeine for this.

The mug was scalding hot against Catra's palm. *Perfect*.

"Okay. Now I'm ready. I hope." It almost felt like she was talking to the coffee. Thankfully, it had nothing to add.

Her tail (decidedly less puffed up) lashed with anticipation, curling and uncurling around the backrest of the sofa. She couldn't sit still, shifting as she leaned forward to restart the listening process.

Maybe she should save these. You know, in case of an emergency.

First new—

Saved.

Second—

Saved.

One more deep breath.

Third new message. Received today, at twelve twenty-seven a.m.

Adora sounded like she was panting slightly. Catra could pick out the sound of her feet pounding against the sidewalk, just short of a jog. "I feel—um, I feel like I need to say that I'm not scared of *mice*. I love animals. I've held rats and ferrets and stuff—*domestic* rats, okay?—it's just. There's a chance of, you know. Being rabid. *Rabidity*." There was a beat where she stopped moving, catching her breath. Very firmly, she added: "Animals—*wild* animals—that are docile and not afraid of people are *not normal*."

This was insane. This was funny as *fuck*. Adora was just… sending these in the middle of the night, from the middle of the street?

Received today, at twelve thirty-eight a.m.

"Okay. I had a point to this that wasn't about the—*agh*, the mouse. Oh my God, why am I scared of a mouse? I—I was trying to say—oh, God, it's following me again—that if you still want to see me tomorrow—um, today—that it's okay if it's too much—oh *God*, oh *crap*."

Adora's words were interrupted by a loud series of clunks, and got very distant, very quickly. Catra's eyebrows crept up in amusement. The dummy had dropped her phone. But before she had, she'd been babbling about their plans for today. She was worried Catra wouldn't want to see her again?

Fuck.

The raw emotional onslaught from earlier was nothing compared to the thrum of warmth blossoming in Catra's stomach as she sat, barely hearing the increasing volume, frequency, and panic for every, "oh my God".

She tuned back in to hear Adora, borderline sing-song, muttering, "Hi, mouse. Please let me get the top off. Please, oh goddamn please." After a few more seconds, there was a scrape and a murmur. "Nothing even cracked. Huh. Oh, crap, it's still recording, I—God help me." One second. Two seconds. Three— "I got the lid off," Adora mumbled weakly.

…twelve fifty a.m.

"I'm just. I'm leaning into this now. Mouse update. It's still not running away, which is still *freaky*. And—oh *no*. There's a car." Catra heard the growl of the engine growing rapidly closer, and Adora's volume rose with it. "Oh, I swear, if I watch this mouse get run over after all of this—! Oh-kay. Didn't get run over. God, I hope this is at least kind of entertaining? Oh, no, it's watching me again."

Who would need books, when Adora willingly sent a spoken-word novella about the plight of a single, dehydrated mouse?

Then: a few tentative footsteps. A quiet grunt of effort. A shift into a soft, careful tone.

"Hello mouse, hi. Yeah, um. Here's some water, I got it for *you*. That's… water. Is that a good amount of water?"

This might actually end Catra's life. Jesus H. Fucking Christ.

…one oh-three a.m.

"Okay. Mouse update, two. It's finished, like, three caps of water. Now it's just… staring at me. I don't know what to do." After the recognizable crinkle of a plastic water bottle, Catra heard Adora's shoes as they scuffed against the sidewalk. From the slow pace, Catra would guess that she was backing away. "Please? Don't touch me. Okay—please stop following—don't follow me. Oh, Catra. This was all so ridiculous, I'm sorry." Her footsteps quickened as she bumbled out her conclusion: "Thank you for hiking Mystacor Point with me, sorry if I was being pushy about

seeing you again, and you're… welcome? For mouse story? God, what a mess." The laugh at herself cut short.

God. *Mouse story*. This ordeal was going to live rent-free in Catra's memory, possibly forever.

Seven. The final voicemail. Catra composed herself as best she could.

Last new message. Received today, at one forty-two a.m.

The quality of Adora's voice was much warmer in this one. Not quite muffled, but less echoing. Catra realized that she must be inside—at long last.

"Hello, again. I… can't believe I did all of that and sent it all to you and—yeah." Adora paused to yawn. Going by the staticky sound and sudden closeness of her murmuring, she must have dragged the phone across the sheets of her bed to her face. "All I meant to say was that I really enjoyed today—or, yesterday. And I hope it isn't too… intense to want to see you again tomo—*today*. But. If you listened to all of these, maybe we're good." Another yawn, muffled, possibly buried into a pillow. "I had… a wonderful time." A low, contented hum. "Can't wait to see you. G'night, Catra."

Catra took a long, slow sip of coffee.

Over the course of, at most, ten minutes of semi-coherent rambling, Catra felt like she'd been taken on another hike. How was Adora so kind, so open, so present? The first Adora she'd met was leagues away from the one she was starting to know.

All those nerves and bumbling sparks of real insight. The sincerity, the thoughtfulness, the undeniably baffling determination.

It made Catra want to jump her goddamn bones.

Her phone lay idle on the coffee table. Her fingers itched to pick it up. And do what, exactly? Call her? At this time?

Then again, if Adora was into hiking, why wouldn't she be awake at such ungodly hours?

The urge was overpowering. Catra decided to ignore the fact that this behavior was wildly out of her comfort zone, snatched the device up, and unflinchingly called her back.

Hell, this was something she could add to the list to bring up in therapy. The list wasn't *particularly* long, but this could be a talking point for at least two sessions, if Catra chose to ham it up. Really rub it in.

Adora picked up on the second ring, yanking Catra back into herself.

"Catra! Hi, good morning, how are you? Did you sleep okay?"

Can 'awake' be an understatement? Because somehow, Adora was more than awake.

"Hey, Adora." The coffee had smoothed over some of Catra's morning voice, but the rasp hadn't quite worked off yet. "How I *am* is awake before noon. I slept—and don't say *anything* about this, I'll just deny it—really fucking well."

"Great. That's just—great."

Catra sighed, a smile dancing at her lips. She should put Adora out of her misery.

"About your voicemails—"

"Okay, um. I'm so sorry. I didn't think beyond the first one, and then—well, I sent the second one. And then… the next one. I—"

Catra interrupted her, sharp, but definitely smiling even more broadly. "Adora!"

"Yes. Sorry. What?"

"It was…" Catra took a breath. There were so many words she could use: sweet, endearing, downright painfully wholesome. But nothing felt quite *right*. So she settled for her favorite play. Teasing. "It was entertaining, for sure."

Adora let out an indignant huff.

"Okay, fine." The smile twisted into a smirk. "You're just so cute when you're scared shitless."

At *that*, Adora made a choking sound. "That's *worse*! That's so much worse! And I wasn't scared… *shitless*. I was—I was—"

"You ran away from a mouse, Adora," Catra replied, matter-of-fact, calmly flexing her claws. She was sure that her casual demeanor was palpable, despite the visual barrier.

"I. I did run away from a mouse," Adora quietly acquiesced, sounding vaguely humbled.

Catra stretched out, draping herself across the entire couch. A shaft of sunlight would be on this exact spot fairly soon, after all. Being prepared was only sensible. She put the call on speaker and left the phone on her stomach.

"So, where d'you think the mouse is now? I bet after it drank its fill, it scampered off into the night and got into all kinds of mischief."

Adora didn't say anything.

Catra frowned slightly. "Adora? You good?"

"Um. Yeah. All good."

That didn't sound *all good*.

"Adora," Catra said, propping herself up on an elbow to make sure she could be heard clearly. "What aren't you telling me?"

“Where—what was the last thing you remember me saying? About the mouse.”

Slowly, enunciating each word, Catra said, “That it had some water and then you walked away. Why?”

“Ah. Right. Um.” Then, Adora mumbled something; she spoke so softly, Catra’s keen ears almost didn't catch it. It sounded suspiciously like, “I took her in…” But that couldn’t be it. *Surely* not.

“What was that?”

More firmly, Adora repeated herself: “I took her in.”

Catra sat up so hard, her phone was (for the second time today, if anyone was counting) absolutely catapulted to the floor. “You *took it in*?”

Even from afar, Catra heard Adora’s voice, so impossibly sweet, yet carried by her signature chin-jut of confidence: “Yes.”

Running a hand through her hair, still exasperated, somehow even more endeared, Catra scrambled to retrieve her phone from where it tumbled underneath the table.

It seemed as though Adora hadn’t noticed the commotion, because she calmly added, “If it helps, I don’t think she’s rabid.”

Still slouched over, Catra let out a disbelieving laugh. “You don’t *think*?”

“She drank the water! And animals with rabies are afraid of water!”

This fucking dork.

“Jesus, Adora.” Catra’s free hand rubbed soothing circles into her temple as she pushed back to her feet. “Has it bitten you?”

“No, nothing like that. She’s been happy in her little box fort the whole night.”

Catra rose to her full height, a sudden connection made. “I was *going* to ask about the box fort, but—how do you know it’s a she?”

There was a drawn out pause. “Before bed, I did some research.”

Catra was right. This mouse ordeal *was* going to be the end of her.

“I could have held the mouse.”

“I—She already knows me.”

Catra sighed, turning to superficially adjust the car mirror as a poor excuse to hide the smile threatening at her lips. Not that Adora was likely to notice, given how intently she was gripping the cardboard box in her lap, carefully lifting the lid to peek inside almost obsessively.

“You—” Catra’s words caught in her throat for a moment. She gripped the steering wheel a little more tightly. “You care a lot, don’t you?”

In the reflection, she caught sight of Adora blinking her gaze up and away from the box to look at Catra. She swore she could actually feel Adora’s eyes burning into her cheek, but stoically kept her own trained on the road.

“I do,” Adora said carefully. Unsure.

Catra took a deep breath. She was committed, now. “It’s sort of rare. In the city. In the world, probably.”

“I guess so,” she murmured. “It’s not always, um, easy.”

Catra instinctively matched her volume. “What isn’t?”

Even softer than before: “Doing the right thing.”

A true quiet fell over the two of them. It was comfortable, if unusual. Adora always liked to fill silences. Instead, the car was alive with the rhythmic sound of a thigh thumping lightly against the leather seat, the corner edges of cardboard being picked at by anxious fingers, the soft squeaks and pitter-patter of an inquisitive rodent roaming its transport container.

Apprehensive, Catra let her tail gently rest on Adora’s forearm, wordlessly offering what she hoped would be taken as goodwill. Out of the corner of her eye, she saw Adora’s shoulders drop down an inch or two. She felt her hands soften, too, which she suddenly realized had been causing her claws to dig into the wheel.

Within minutes, they had pulled into the gravel lot at the start of the hike up to Mystacor Point.

Catra fully parked the car, but made no move to take out the keys. She sighed, mostly to herself, and looked to Adora.

“Are you sure about this?”

Adora nodded.

“Do you need me to come with?”

Adora paused.

“Do you *want* me to come with?”

A small smile broke out across Adora’s face. She undid her seatbelt and happily started clambering out the door. Catra rolled her eyes, grabbed the keys out of the ignition, and followed suit.

End Notes

Catra, post-credits: "You realize that you called *me* about a mouse. You *have* to see how that looks, right?"

Anyway! This is technically a complete standalone. *However*, it's also technically within the canon of a, uh… *huge* project I'm doing in the background right now. I've kept the "lore" (for lack of a better word) fairly scant for this one-shot. But this was a randomly inspired (again, not by real events whatsoever) idea that happens to so, *so* beautifully slot into that story. Anyway, anyway. I love Adora with my whole goddamn heart, and I want to be a mouse that she saves and carries around in a little box, please and thank you.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!